Prologue

Sometimes, in the dimly lit passages of time, there shines a light so bright it dazzles the ages. Such was the flare, at any rate, that burst across the Mongolian sky one dark night, blazing into Alanqoa's tent, her astonished mouth, and then her womb.

Who knows when Alanqoa lived? Over 2000 years before she saw the light of day, her luckless ancestor Qiyan had seen his entire tribe massacred. Only Qiyan, his cousin and their wives survived. The four found refuge in Argana-qun, an Edenic valley surrounded by high mountains; and here, upon a meadow lush with water and fruit, the tribe rebuilt itself. Eventually, when the valley would hold them no longer, the men and women travelled out, no longer fugitives but an unstoppable force. An iron mountain that blocked their way they melted with bellows. Two millennia after Qiyan's desperate escape, his descendants – the Qiyat – returned to rule Mongolia.

Alanqoa was a Qiyat, married to her cousin, the king – but when that light flew into her tent, the king was long dead and Alanqoa herself ruled the Mongols. Anticipating protests from literal-minded chieftains who might not understand how their widowed queen was suddenly with child, she commanded some trustworthy men to witness the miracle. They stood guard around her tent as the stars rose and the darkness grew, their silence interrupted by the unearthly sounds of night and the shuffling of feet.

And then, as one, the men let out a cry. It was as Alanqoa had said! A magnificent light had made its unerring way across the sky and into the tent of their queen.

Nine months later, she delivered three boys: Baqun Qataqi, Bughutu Salji and Bodhonchar Qa'an. Few in the modern world will find their names familiar; yet few in the modern world will not have heard of their descendants. Chinghis Khan, Timur the Lame, Akbar the Great – men who would grab the world by the scruff of its neck and claim it as their own. And why should they not? They were, after all, the Niru'un. Born of Light.